

Flyers on billboards, newspaper advertisements to those blocks, or specially targeted online ads would be a good start. Since the target area is so small, they could afford to pay a premium to create a high level of awareness in the target zone. The total cost would remain quite small.

As a comprehensive solution to the problem of financial abuse, this minimum viable product is not very good compared with what a \$500 million agency could accomplish. But it is also not very expensive. This product could be built in a matter of days or weeks, and the whole experiment probably would cost only a few thousand dollars.

What we would learn from this experiment would be invaluable. On the basis of the selections of those first callers, the agency could immediately start to get a sense of what kinds of problems Americans believe they have, not just what they “should” have. The agency could begin to test marketing messages: What motivates people to call? It could start to extrapolate real-world trends: What percentage of people in the target area actually call? The extrapolation would not be perfect, but it would establish a baseline behavior that would be far more accurate than market research.

Most important, this product would serve as a seed that could germinate into a much more elaborate service. With this beginning, the agency could engage in a continuous process of improvement, slowly but surely adding more and better solutions. Eventually, it would staff the hotline with caseworkers, perhaps at first addressing only one category of problems, to give the caseworkers the best chance of success. By the time the official plan was ready for implementation, this early service could serve as a real-world template.

The CFPB is just getting started, but already they are showing signs of following an experimental approach. For example, instead of doing a geographically limited rollout, they are segmenting their first products by use case. They have established a preliminary order of financial products to provide consumer services for, with credit cards coming first. As their first experiment unfolds, they will